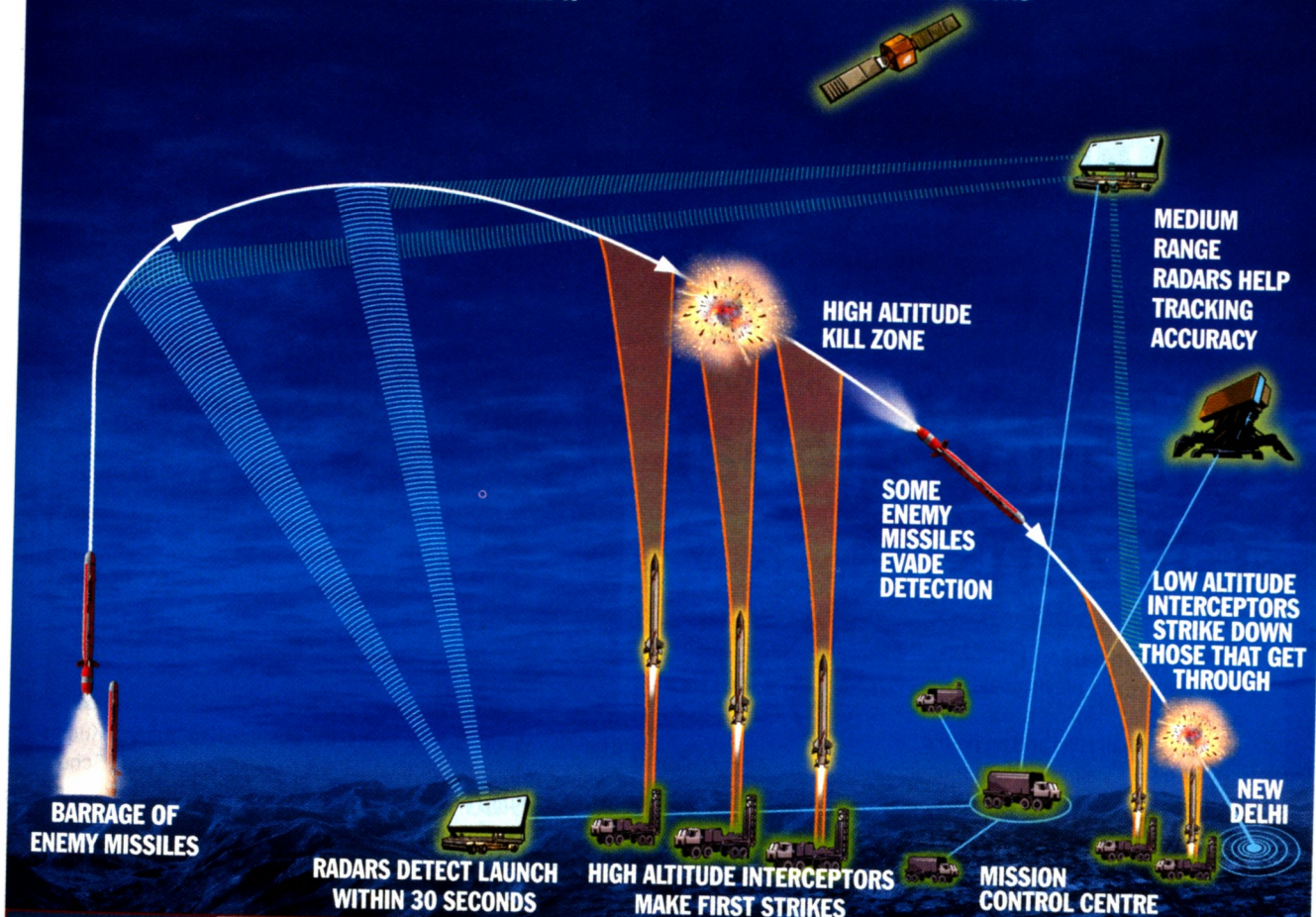


DEFENDING DELHI

How the nation's Capital could be defended if nuke-tipped missiles are launched to strike it

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Rs 5,200 cr is what it will cost to equip Delhi with an effective missile defence system

the launch, as is tradition, a pundit was called to perform a *pooja* at the site. Such was the confidence level that the team joked and had their pictures taken in front of the missile.

For mission director Saraswat, who had helped build the Prithvi, it was his 34th launch and he calmly oversaw the countdown. There was a ripple of excitement in the mission control centre block house as 150 km away a Prithvi was launched from Balasore to act as the enemy missile. Immediately, the radar on the large screen picked up its progress and drew a parabolic line as it headed towards Wheeler Island. Four long minutes later, the computer ordered the firing of AAD01. A line appeared on the radar screen tracing its flight. Then just 24 seconds later at a height of 15 km above the earth the

two lines intersected indicating that the interceptor had made a direct hit. A huge cheer broke out in the block house and the jubilant team lifted Saraswat on their shoulders almost like a soccer star. Minutes later, Saraswat told INDIA TODAY, "We now have the capability of making a potent missile defence shield."

Experts acknowledge that the two tests herald India's entry in the ABM club but as Jasjit points out, "These are important steps but we are still a long way from having an effective shield." Ashley Tellis, a Washington-based US missile expert, called the tests, "very impressive, even awesome" but says these are "proof of concepts" and a lot more would have to be done to make it operational. DRDO chief M. Natarajan acknowledges that what India has

developed are only "key building blocks". The Indian team would still have to develop longer-range radars and faster interceptors to destroy intermediate-range ballistic missiles that can travel more than 2,000 km. The cost of such systems could be prohibitive too—a missile shield for Delhi alone would cost Rs 5,200 crore.

Meanwhile the other four nations having ABM systems are also just at the early stages of making them operational (see chart). The US had ambitious plans to build an astrodome kind of protection essentially against missiles launched by rogue nations or non-state actors. A decade later America still has only a rudimentary operational system in place. The admiration for India's effort to build a missile shield is, therefore, well founded.